Credit: John Webb / The Art Archive at Art Resource, NY

But Sulayman had apparently concluded that Ibn Battuta was harmless, and the honors soothed the traveler's offended pride somewhat. During the two months he remained in Mali, Ibn Battuta paid grudging respect to the safety and justice of the kingdom: "A traveller may proceed alone among them, without the least fear of a thief or robber," he noted. He also praised their piety, noting that it was common for the men of Mali to commit the entire Koran to memory. In al-'Umari's words,

> Their king at present is named Sulayman, brother of the sultan Musa Mansa. He controls, of the land of Sudan, that which his brother brought together by conquest and added to the domains of Islam. There he built ordinary and cathedral mosques and minarets, and established the Friday observances and prayers in congregation, and the muezzin's call. . . . This king is the greatest of the Muslim kings of the Sudan. He rules the most extensive territory, has the most numerous army, is the bravest, the richest, the most fortunate, the most victorious over his enemies.[8]

In Sulayman's twenty-four years on the throne, Mali remained firmly under his authority. His subjects, Ibn Battuta says, "debase themselves . . . in the presence of their king" more than any other people, prostrating themselves and throwing dust upon their heads. Sulayman surrounded himself with the trappings of an emperor: gold arms and armor; ranks of courtiers and Turkish mamluks, warrior slaves bought from Egypt, surrounding him. They were required to keep solemn and attentive in his presence: "Whoever sneezes while the king is holding court," al-'Umari explains, "is severely beaten."[9]

But at Sulayman's death, in 1359, the political factions that had been slowly coalescing during his reign—each one centered on a different descendant of Mansa Musa—broke the country apart.

A civil war erupted between the supporters of Sulayman's son Fomba and one of the sons of Maghan, Mari Diata II. After a year of fighting, Fomba was killed and Mari Diata II seized the throne: "A most wicked ruler over them," says the fourteenth-century chronicler Ibn Khaldun, "because of the tortures, tyrannies, and improprieties to which he subjected them."[10]

In the wake of the coup, a chunk of Mali between the Senegal and Gambia rivers revolted. Instead of submitting to the despotic Mari Diata, three distinct but neighboring clans—Waalo, Baol, and Kajoor, all of them Wolof-speakers